



INVICTUS NASHVILLE CHARTER SCHOOL

STUDENT & FAMILY HANDBOOK

2025-2026

Your guide to how we learn, grow, and work together as a community.

Questions? Contact us at info@invictus-nash.org or visit www.invictus-nash.org.

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A note on these policies

The policies summarized in this handbook are grounded in the INCS Policy Handbook, publicly available at www.invictus-nash.org. Where this handbook references a specific INCS policy, the Policy Handbook is the authoritative source.

SECTION 01

INTRODUCTION & OUR MODEL

A Welcome from Our Director

Dear Invictus Families,

Welcome to Invictus Nashville! It is with great pride and purpose that we welcome you to another year of learning, growth, and community. As Nashville's first public Montessori charter school, our mission is to nurture the whole child through a joyful, rigorous, and identity-affirming education. We believe that every student deserves the opportunity to thrive academically, socially, and emotionally.

This Student & Family Handbook is your guide to understanding how we work together as a community. Inside, you will find key information about our school's policies, procedures, expectations, and supports. We hope this handbook empowers you to stay engaged, informed, and connected throughout the year.

The policies summarized in this handbook are grounded in INCS's adopted Policy Handbook, which is publicly available on our website. Where this handbook references a specific INCS policy, the Policy Handbook is the authoritative source.

Thank you for entrusting us with your child's education. We look forward to partnering with you to ensure that every child grows into a healthy, happy, whole human.

With gratitude,

Dr. Brenda Jones

Achieving Our Vision

Invictus Nashville Charter School is Nashville's first public Montessori charter school. Our mission is to develop **healthy, happy, whole humans** through a joyful, rigorous, and identity-affirming education. Our model combines Montessori principles, strong academic foundations, culturally affirming practices, and deep partnership with families. Our vision is grounded in five key elements.

1**1****Montessori Education**

Students learn through hands-on materials, purposeful work, student choice, and carefully prepared classroom environments. Teachers guide students toward independence, concentration, responsibility, and mastery. Montessori learning is aligned to Tennessee Academic Standards while honoring each child's academic, social, emotional, and developmental growth.

2**2****Whole-Child Mentoring & Support**

Students are known, supported, and celebrated through intentional relationship-building. Mentoring structures help students build self-awareness, set goals, reflect on their growth, and develop the social and emotional skills needed to thrive in school and life.

3**3****Community Expeditions**

Throughout the year, students participate in Community Expedition experiences that extend learning beyond the classroom—service projects, visits to local organizations, conversations with community members, and hands-on exploration connected to classroom learning. These experiences build curiosity, purpose, and a deeper connection to Nashville.

4**4****Connected Community**

Invictus Nashville is intentionally diverse by design. We believe children benefit from learning in a community that reflects the racial, cultural, linguistic, and socioeconomic diversity of Nashville. We are committed to building a school where students and families experience belonging and where differences are celebrated.

5**5****An Inspiring Professional Culture**

Excellent schools require excellent educators who are trusted, supported, and empowered. Invictus Nashville cultivates a professional culture rooted in respect, collaboration, growth, and shared responsibility for student success.

School Hours

Breakfast is available beginning at **7:30 a.m.** The school day starts at **8:00 a.m.** Punctuality protects and prioritizes instructional time each day. Being on time demonstrates respect for our staff and for the engaging learning experiences that await students every morning.

INCS offers before-school care from 6:30 to 7:30 a.m. for families who need early drop-off. After-school care runs until 6:00 p.m. on Monday, Tuesday, Wednesday, and Friday, and until 2:30 p.m. on Thursdays. Families are responsible for before- and after-care payments.

Before-school care	6:30 – 7:30 a.m. (optional, paid)
Breakfast available	Begins 7:30 a.m.
Instructional day begins	8:00 a.m.
After-school care • Mon, Tue, Wed, Fri	Until 6:00 p.m. (optional, paid)
After-school care • Thursday	Until 2:30 p.m. (optional, paid)

Inclement weather

In case of inclement weather, school hours may be impacted. Please monitor our website and social media for the latest information. **Please do not call the school for closing information.**

● School closing

If MNPS schools are closed, INCS will also be closed on the first day of a closing. If MNPS is closed for more than one consecutive day, check your email and INCS social media to see whether INCS will open—bus routes to our school may clear before MNPS can reopen district-wide.

● Early dismissal

If inclement weather causes an early dismissal, we will notify all parents through email and a phone call, in addition to posting on INCS social media.

STAY INFORMED

The fastest ways to receive closing and dismissal news are **email**, our **phone notifications**, and **Invictus Nashville social media**. Make sure your contact information is current with the front office.

Academic Calendar

The current academic calendar is available at www.invictus-nash.org/family-resources and is updated each school year. Printed copies are available at the school office upon request.

SECTION 02

ACADEMICS AT INVICTUS NASHVILLE

Standards

Tennessee Academic Standards provide the foundation for all learning activities at Invictus Nashville. The standards are **what** we learn, our Montessori instructional methods are **how** we learn, and our holistic focus provides the **why** for our learning activities and approach.

Curriculum & Instructional Methods

Our instructional methods blend the progressive, child-centered Montessori approach with best practices for promoting equitable outcomes for all students, including students with special needs and English language learners.

A key element of Montessori education at INCS is the structure of the day in extended work cycles. All students participate in two extended daily work cycles of 2–3 hours each—one in the morning and one in the afternoon, one focused on Math and one on Literacy—led by the two classroom teachers. Enrichment (Art, PE) is incorporated daily and has a dedicated classroom rotation time.

Freedom Within Limits

We believe children thrive when given the opportunity to make choices within a thoughtfully prepared environment. This Montessori principle, known as **Freedom Within Limits**, empowers students to grow as independent thinkers while learning to respect boundaries that keep the community safe and productive. Students are guided by four core freedoms:

● **Freedom of Movement**

Students may move around the classroom respectfully to meet their learning needs.

● **Freedom of Choice**

Students choose work that interests them from a range of developmentally appropriate, teacher-prepared options.

● **Freedom of Time**

Uninterrupted work periods allow students to dive deeply into tasks and build focus.

● **Freedom to Communicate**

Students may collaborate and engage in respectful dialogue with peers and teachers.

These freedoms are not without expectations—they are earned and nurtured through trust, responsibility, and care for the learning community.

Instructional Methods & Strategies

Instruction in our work cycles incorporates research-supported practices designed to provide individualized, equitable learning and to maximize student voice and independence.

Literacy

Content-Based Literacy	A hands-on, developmentally responsive approach that nurtures a love of reading, writing, speaking, and listening—beginning with oral language and phonemic awareness through storytelling, songs, and conversation, then tactile materials like sandpaper letters and moveable alphabets. Students are then guided through increasingly complex reading and writing tasks matched to their pace and interests.
Foundational Skills	We combine the Montessori For All Reading Curriculum with Core Knowledge Language Arts (CKLA). CKLA provides structured, research-based phonics, decoding, spelling, and comprehension; Montessori For All reinforces these skills through hands-on materials and child-led exploration.
Interactive Read Aloud	The teacher reads from an engaging text and periodically prompts students to turn and talk, modeling skills students will then explore and practice independently afterward.
Skill / Intervention Groups	Benchmark assessments inform grouping by target skill. Literacy groups meet weekly with the teacher to work on phonics, comprehension, features of text, and vocabulary.

Mathematics

Concrete to Abstract	Using Montessori materials, students explore math with their hands first—building deep, lasting understanding—before moving to abstract symbols and algorithms.
Math Workshop	Daily collaborative choral learning reinforces previously taught concepts and builds math fluency.
Integrated Math Technology	An online platform introduces and reinforces key skills during a designated daily time block.
Small Groups / Intervention	Teachers form targeted groups based on specific concepts to support students who need additional access to grade-level standards.

Sample Student Schedule

7:45 – 8:00	Arrival & breakfast
8:00 – 8:30	Breakfast continues & mentoring
8:30 – 10:30	Montessori work cycle (ELA, Math, Practical Life, Sensorial, Culture)
10:30 – 11:10	Outdoor recess (minimum 40 minutes)
11:10 – 11:40	Lunch
11:40 – 12:30	Enrichment block (Art & P.E.)
12:30 – 1:15	PreK nap / K-2 read aloud & literacy mini-lesson
1:15 – 3:00	Afternoon work cycle (Science, Cultural Studies, independent work)
3:00 – 3:15	Pack up, choice time & reflection
3:15	Dismissal

Academic Grades & Report Cards

Report cards are issued to parents at the end of each quarter. They communicate student achievement in relation to the standards-aligned Montessori lessons for the marking period, as well as reading level in English and behavioral developmental updates—providing a comprehensive picture of each student's progress as a lifelong learner and contributing member of our community.

Homework Policy

The Montessori philosophy recognizes that children learn best through hands-on experiences, deep concentration, and purposeful work—at school and at home. Children in primary and lower elementary should spend at least **30 minutes reading each day**: independent reading, reading aloud to a family member, listening to an audiobook, or reading together as a family. Beyond reading, families may explore these optional, Montessori-aligned activities:

- **Take a meaningful role in family life** — help with yard work, table setting, meal planning, caring for pets, or errands.
- **Spend time outdoors** — run, ride a bike, climb, explore natural spaces, or care for plants.
- **Engage in self-directed activities** — make art or music, write stories, measure rooms, research a favorite animal, or practice cursive.
- **Play and interact with others** — enjoy unstructured play with siblings or friends.
- **Share conversation with a trusted adult** — talk about the day, ask questions, and reflect on feelings and experiences.

Make-Up Work

If a student is absent for a full or partial day, the guide will provide targeted instruction and support to help the student complete any missed assignments. All make-up work must be submitted within **one week** of the original due date.

Academic Honesty

At Invictus Nashville, students are learning what it means to take ownership of their work, tell the truth, and contribute honestly to the learning community. Academic honesty includes doing one's own work, giving credit for the ideas of others, using technology responsibly, and asking for help when needed.

Because our students are still developing these skills, concerns about academic honesty are addressed in a developmentally appropriate way. Teachers will first seek to understand what happened, reteach expectations, and help the student repair the situation when needed. Repeated or serious concerns may involve family communication, reflection, additional support, and appropriate school-based consequences. Our goal is to help students grow as responsible, honest, and reflective learners.

Special Education & Support Services

All INCS students with disabilities are entitled to a free appropriate public education and are provided services and programs as prescribed by their Individualized Education Plans (IEPs) or 504 Plans. All services and placement decisions are made by the IEP or 504 team based on the individual needs of each student.

INCS uses an **inclusion model** to the fullest extent possible, meaning most students with an IEP receive services within the general education classroom with targeted interventions by specialists. This approach benefits both students with IEPs and their typically developing peers.

Families with questions about their child's eligibility, current services, or rights under the Individuals with Disabilities Education Act (IDEA) or Section 504 of the Rehabilitation Act are encouraged to contact the INCS Special Education Coordinator or the ADA/Section 504 Coordinator. The full Special Education policy and the Section 504 Due Process procedures are available in the INCS Policy Handbook at www.invictus-nash.org.

ADA / Section 504 Coordinator

Damoniece Lowe, Assistant Head of Schools
2526 Lebanon Pike, Nashville, TN 37214
615-378-5490 · dlowe@invictus-nash.org

English Learners

Our school model is intentionally designed to meet the needs of English Learners. Adaptations and modifications of assignments, assessments, and the classroom environment are provided as indicated by the student's IEP or 504 Plan, and special accommodations are given during state and district assessments.

SECTION 03

CULTURE AT INVICTUS NASHVILLE

Grace & Courtesy Expectations

We believe each child is capable of developing into a kind, confident, and contributing member of our school community. Rooted in the Montessori principles of **freedom within limits**, **respect for the child**, and **care for the environment**, our approach to behavior emphasizes proactive community-building, individual responsibility, and social-emotional development.

Our commitments as a community

These commitments are not rules but shared values that guide how we show up for ourselves and one another:

- I commit to cultivating joy.
- I commit to being kind and curious.
- I commit to walking my talk.
- I commit to recognizing potential in myself and others.
- I commit to attending to my relationships.
- I commit to celebrating our differences.

These commitments are integrated into daily classroom life through modeling, dialogue, and student reflection. Each learning environment reinforces them in age-appropriate ways, recognizing the developmental needs of each child.

Behavior as Communication

We understand that behavior is a form of communication. When a child exhibits a behavior that disrupts the community or causes harm, we seek first to understand the underlying need. Behavioral challenges often arise when a child feels unseen, unsure of expectations, or disconnected from their work. Our first response is to ensure:

- Clear modeling of procedures and expectations
- Meaningful, hands-on learning that engages the whole child
- Consistent routines that foster a sense of security
- Strong, trusting relationships between guides and students

Children are guided to develop self-regulation, conflict resolution, and care for others through natural consequences, reflection, and restorative conversations—rather than punitive measures.

Responsive Classroom Practices

Our guides use Responsive Classroom strategies and Montessori Grace & Courtesy lessons to establish a safe, joyful, and inclusive community. These practices prioritize both academic and social-emotional learning:

- Social and emotional growth is equally important to academic learning.
- Learning is most powerful through meaningful relationships and community dialogue.
- The classroom environment and adult modeling shape behavior as much as direct instruction.
- Families are essential partners in the development of the whole child.

Each day, children engage in **Community Meetings**, **Peace Table** conversations, and reflection time, where they learn and practice empathy, accountability, and collaboration.

Harm & Bullying Prevention

We are committed to nurturing a culture where every child feels safe, respected, and valued. We differentiate between **conflict**—a normal part of social development—and **bullying**, which is deliberate, repeated harm caused by an imbalance of power. Bullying may include:

• Physical aggression

For example, hitting or pushing.

• Verbal harm

For example, insults, threats, or teasing.

• Social exclusion

For example, spreading rumors or isolation.

• Emotional intimidation

For example, coercion or manipulation.

When harm occurs, we respond with **restorative practices** that help children repair relationships, build empathy, and regain trust. Our goal is not to punish, but to heal and empower. All children involved receive support to grow their understanding and skills. When additional support is needed, members of our leadership team or an external counselor may engage with small groups or individuals to foster prosocial behaviors and emotional literacy.

FULL POLICY

INCS's full bullying, harassment, and discrimination policy—including definitions of prohibited conduct, protected categories, and reporting procedures—is contained in the INCS Policy Handbook (TPCSC LEA Policy 6304). To report a concern, follow the steps in **How to Raise a Concern** in Section 4.

SECTION 04

POLICIES & PROCEDURES

Acceptable Use of Technology

We believe technology should be used intentionally and thoughtfully to support student learning and development. While Montessori classrooms are not 1:1 device environments, students do have access to technology as a supplemental resource—primarily for research, enrichment, and skill-building. The objectives of our technology integration are to:

- Build students' confidence and skills using digital tools and applications
- Foster critical and creative thinking
- Encourage responsible use of technology for research and communication
- Support independent and cooperative learning experiences

Our goal is not simply to teach technology, but to use it in developmentally appropriate ways that enhance—not replace—the hands-on, student-centered approach that defines Montessori education.

FULL POLICY

Student use of school technology is governed by the INCS Acceptable Use Policy (TPCSC LEA Policy 4406). Families will be asked to sign a Technology and Device Agreement at the start of each school year. Violations may result in loss of technology privileges and disciplinary consequences consistent with the INCS student discipline policy.

Artificial Intelligence (AI)

INCS has adopted an Artificial Intelligence Use Policy (TPCSC LEA Policy 4213, adopted 2026–27) governing how students and staff may use AI tools in connection with school work and activities. The full policy is available in the INCS Policy Handbook.

● Students

Students may use AI tools freely in support of their learning **when explicitly guided by a teacher**. Teachers establish the parameters of appropriate AI use in their classrooms. Where a teacher has not provided explicit guidance, students should assume AI use is not permitted for that task.

● Privacy

No student personally identifiable information—as defined under FERPA—may be entered into any AI tool not covered by an approved data privacy agreement. Questions about approved tools may be directed to info@invictus-nash.org.

This policy is reviewed annually by the Head of Schools and updated before the start of each school year, given the rapidly evolving nature of AI technology.

Attendance Policy

INCS has an average daily attendance goal of at least **95%** of students in attendance each day. We expect all students to attend school every day.

Excused absences

The following are accepted reasons for an excused absence:

- Child's illness
- Serious illness in the family
- Head lice, maximum of three days
- Death in the family
- Religious holiday
- One day before and one day upon the return of a parent or guardian deployed on active military service; up to ten cumulative days per year to visit a deployed parent or guardian (documentation required)

Special circumstances—such as housing difficulties, transportation difficulties, or required family travel—may be approved at the discretion of school leadership. When possible, parents should notify the front office in advance. Parents must justify an absence in writing within **five days** for it to be excused.

Intervention ladder

To reduce chronic absence (missing 10% or more of school days), INCS implements progressive interventions:

Not excused in advance	Contact guardians by call or text
3 unexcused absences	Written attendance notification sent home
5 unexcused absences	Attendance meeting with guardian; Attendance Improvement Plan developed and shared; truancy letter sent home
7 unexcused absences	Attendance meeting with guardian; Improvement Plan reviewed and updated; truancy next steps shared
10 unexcused absences	INCS is mandated by the Compulsory School Attendance Law (T.C.A. § 49-6-3001) to report a truancy concern to the Juvenile Courts. The Head of School communicates this requirement to families.

YOUR RIGHT TO APPEAL

Students have the right to an attendance hearing to appeal a determination of unexcused absence. The full attendance policy, including the three-tier progressive truancy plan and hearing procedures, is in the INCS Policy Handbook (TPCSC LEA Policy 6200).

Classroom Placement

INCS places students in heterogeneous classrooms at each grade level. Placements are determined by the school leadership team. Families may make requests, but ultimately placement is the decision of school leadership. In rare cases, classroom assignments may change during the year based on the needs of students and the school community.

Communication

Parents must be informed of the current curriculum, major assignments, projects, upcoming events, extension activities for home, and other pertinent information. The following guidelines inform communication during the year:

- Teachers keep in close contact by email, phone, or notes home—especially when there are areas of concern and when there is good news to share.
- Teachers have up to **48 hours** during the workweek to respond to parent questions or requests.
- INCS leadership offers special parent information sessions during the year.

Montessori-Friendly Dress Code

Our dress code is intentionally designed to support the Montessori approach by promoting comfort, independence, and focus. How a child is dressed should help—not hinder—their ability to move freely, engage deeply, and feel confident in the classroom.

What students should wear

Students may wear solid-colored or patterned t-shirts or polo shirts, in long- or short-sleeve styles. Bottoms may include pull-on pants, shorts, skorts, or leggings; we strongly prefer soft fabric and elastic waistbands. Skirts and dresses are welcome but should be worn with shorts or leggings underneath. For layering, students may wear cardigans, sweaters, or fleece jackets—hoodies should not be worn during classroom time. Students must wear closed-toe sneakers or flat shoes each day; Velcro-fastened shoes are preferred for younger students. Please avoid light-up shoes, Crocs, sandals, and heels.

Why it matters

■ Dress independently

Clothing should be easy for students to put on and take off without adult help.

■ Move freely

Children should be able to stretch, sit on the floor, and transition between activities comfortably.

■ Stay focused

Simple clothing choices help reduce distractions in the classroom.

■ Feel confident

When students are physically comfortable, they can focus more fully on learning and peers.

Items to avoid

- Clothing with offensive or questionable characters, logos, or graphic prints
- Tight clothing, belts, or restrictive fabrics
- Items with complicated zippers or closures, especially in the back
- Open-toe shoes or Crocs
- Pajamas or sleepwear (reserved for special dress-up or spirit days)

We believe Montessori begins with independence, so we encourage families to let students choose their clothing each day from within the approved options. School leaders may occasionally request a change if a choice becomes disruptive or misaligned with our values. Questions? Email info@invictus-nash.org.

Food in the Classroom

These guidelines are drawn from the INCS School Nutrition and Wellness Policy (IM 4.146, adopted December 4, 2025), the authoritative source.

Celebrations	Limited to twice per month and scheduled after lunch. Coordinate with your child's teacher in advance. A list of healthy snack and celebration ideas is available from the office.
Food as rewards	Food, beverages, and candy may not be used as rewards for performance or behavior. Meals may not be withheld as discipline. This applies to all staff in all settings.
Fundraisers	Food sold during the school day must meet USDA Smart Snacks standards. Up to 20 exempt days per semester are permitted and communicated in advance.

ALLERGY SAFETY

Before bringing any food to share, notify your child's teacher so families of children with documented allergies can be informed. Students with documented dietary needs are served through a separate accommodation process with our food service provider, Panache Catering. Please ensure a current special diet prescription form, signed by a recognized medical authority, is on file with the office.

Emergency Drills

INCS considers the safety of students our top priority. Our exterior doors are locked at all times. To enter, visitors must use a security buzzer equipped with a camera in the front office during school hours.

Throughout the year, teachers, students, and staff participate in the following drills. Schedules are established in the INCS Emergency Operations Plan (EOP), maintained in accordance with the Tennessee SAVE Act (T.C.A. § 49-6-801 et seq.):

Secure	A threat in the surrounding area, not school-specific, could affect the school. No one transitions in or out of the building. INCS maintains ongoing communication with Metro Nashville Police regarding the incident.
Lockdown	A threat of any nature requires all classrooms and exterior doors to remain locked, with no student movement, as the school implements its crisis response plan.
Shelter in Place	A weather-related response in which students remain inside in designated safe areas until the danger has passed.
Fire Drills	Conducted at least once per month (TPCSC LEA Policy 3202). Fire drills require full evacuation of the building.
Tornado Drills	Conducted at least twice per year, with procedures to minimize risk in the event of tornadoes and severe storms.

Families will be notified of reunification procedures in the event of a real emergency. The full emergency response framework is maintained in the INCS Emergency Operations Plan.

FERPA: Your Family's Rights

INCS is required by the Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act (FERPA), 20 U.S.C. § 1232g, to provide families with an annual notice of their rights regarding their child's education records. The full FERPA policy is available in the INCS Policy Handbook. Your key rights include:

- The right to **inspect and review** your child's education records within 45 days of a written request.
- The right to **request amendment** of records you believe are inaccurate or misleading.
- The right to **consent** before INCS discloses personally identifiable information, with limited exceptions permitted by law.
- The right to **file a complaint** with the U.S. Department of Education (Family Policy Compliance Office, 400 Maryland Avenue SW, Washington, D.C. 20202-4605).

DIRECTORY INFORMATION & OPT-OUT

INCS may release certain directory information (name, address, photograph, dates of attendance) without prior written consent unless you direct otherwise. To opt out, notify the school in writing or indicate your choice on the media release form provided at the start of the year.

Harassment & Non-Discrimination

Non-discrimination statement

Invictus Nashville Charter School does not discriminate on the basis of race, color, religion, national origin, sex, gender identity, sexual orientation, disability, age, or any other characteristic protected by law in its programs, services, activities, or employment practices. This commitment applies to admissions, academics, extracurricular activities, and all other aspects of school life.

Harassment

INCS prohibits all forms of harassment, including bullying, discrimination, intimidation, hazing, and sexual harassment. Prohibited harassment based on a student's real or perceived protected characteristics that creates a hostile environment is a serious violation of school policy and applicable law, including Title IX of the Education Amendments of 1972. The complete definitions, prohibited conduct, reporting and investigation procedures, and student protections are set forth in the INCS Policy Handbook (TPCSC LEA Policy 6305).

How to report

Any student, parent, or family member who believes harassment has occurred should report it to the INCS Title IX Coordinator or any trusted staff member, or submit a report in writing to school leadership. INCS responds to all reports promptly and will not retaliate against anyone for making a good-faith report.

Title IX Coordinator

Adam Holdren, Director of Operations
2526 Lebanon Pike, Nashville, TN 37214
aholdren@invictus-nash.org

ADA / Section 504 Coordinator

Damoniece Lowe, Assistant Head of Schools
2526 Lebanon Pike, Nashville, TN 37214
dlowe@invictus-nash.org

OFFICE FOR CIVIL RIGHTS

Complaints may also be filed at any time with the U.S. Department of Education, Office for Civil Rights, 61 Forsyth Street SW, Suite 19T10, Atlanta, GA 30303-8927.

How to Raise a Concern

Open communication between families and school staff is essential to our community. If you have a concern—about your child's experience, a policy, a staff interaction, or any other matter—we want to hear from you and are committed to addressing concerns fairly and promptly.

1

1

Talk to the teacher or staff member directly

Most concerns can be resolved quickly through a conversation with the person most directly involved. Reach out by email or phone to arrange a time to talk.

2

2

Contact school leadership

If a conversation with the teacher does not resolve your concern, or makes a direct conversation difficult, contact the Head of School or Director of Operations.

3

3

Submit a formal written complaint

If your concern is not resolved through Steps 1 and 2, submit a formal written complaint to school leadership. INCS will acknowledge your complaint and respond in writing. Full grievance procedures, including timelines and appeal rights, are in the INCS Policy Handbook (TPCSC LEA Policy 1200).

INCS does not retaliate against any student or family for raising a concern in good faith. If your concern involves a potential violation of federal civil rights law, you have the right to file a complaint directly with the U.S. Department of Education, Office for Civil Rights, at any time, independently of any school-level process.



School contact: info@invictus-nash.org · 615-378-5490 · 2526 Lebanon Pike, Nashville, TN 37214

Language Policy

INCS has a culturally and linguistically diverse community, with many families speaking more than one language at home. Our teaching staff includes native speakers of English and Spanish, including bilingual and multilingual teachers. Although English and Spanish are most common, we encourage the use of other languages as appropriate. The INCS Language Policy is guided by these beliefs:

- Language development is the foundation that allows students to fully access and engage with learning.
- All teachers are language teachers, and all subject-area classes include explicit language instruction.
- Languages are learned best in authentic, meaningful contexts.
- Language provides a direct link to understanding a person's culture and identity.
- Multilingualism is essential in a globally interconnected society.
- Families play a crucial role—promoting the child's mother tongue and supporting developing multilingualism.

Official publications, weekly newsletters, and extracurricular offerings are made available in English and Spanish, with additional translations possible based on need. At the start of each year, parents indicate their preference for written and verbal communication. INCS is committed to identifying and supporting English Learner students in accordance with applicable state and federal requirements.

Mandated Reporting

Tennessee law requires all school employees to report known or suspected child abuse or neglect to the Tennessee Department of Children's Services (DCS) or to local law enforcement. This obligation applies regardless of the source of the information and requires no prior investigation.

What this means for families: INCS staff are required by law to report whenever they have reasonable cause to suspect a child is being abused or neglected. A staff member making a good-faith report is protected from liability under state law even if the report is later determined to be unfounded.

REPORT DIRECTLY TO DCS

If your child or family needs resources or support affecting your well-being, reach out to any INCS teacher or staff member you trust—we are here to help connect you with community resources. To report child abuse or neglect directly:

DCS CHILD ABUSE HOTLINE · 24/7

1-877-237-0004

SCHOOL OFFICE

615-378-5490

Medications & Student Illness

Students should never bring medication to their classroom. Each prescription medication to be administered by school personnel must be accompanied by a signed statement from the physician and parent detailing the dosage and time for administration. The child's doctor must confirm that the medication must be administered at school. All medications are kept in a locked cabinet in the office, and no medication is distributed until a completed form is on file.

WHEN TO KEEP YOUR CHILD HOME

If your child has a temperature of **100.5°F or above**, please do not bring them to school. Students must be fever-free without fever-reducing medication for at least **24 hours** before returning. If your child has vomited in the past 24 hours, keep them home. If your child has or recently had lice, they may not return until nits, eggs, and lice are completely gone.

If a child becomes ill during class, appropriate first aid will be provided in consultation with the student's parents. A child will only be authorized to go home after a parent or guardian has been notified and provided approval.

Parent-Teacher Conferences

Formal Parent-Teacher Conferences are held twice during the year, in the fall and the spring. Additional conferences may be arranged at any time by parents, teachers, and/or INCS directors. To protect instructional time, please call or email to arrange a convenient time to meet—please do not attempt conferences at the classroom door, as teachers are attending to students.

Phones

Students should not use mobile phones or smart watches at any point during the school day. Students who bring devices must leave them turned off in a backpack. Devices used during the school day will be confiscated, to be picked up at the end of the day by a parent.

Release of Students

INCS will only release a student to the parent or guardian of record, or to another adult designated in writing on the student's authorized pickup list. Staff verify the identity of any person picking up a student by requiring a **photo ID**, and the person must sign the student out.

Students will not be released to any person whose behavior, as judged by a reasonable staff member, may place the student at immediate risk. In that situation, staff will not release the child and will call 911 or local law enforcement immediately. If the person is not the parent, the parent will also be called at once. Parents and guardians are permitted access to their children during school operating hours.

CUSTODY & COURT ORDERS

Where a court order limits or prohibits a parent's access, the custodial parent or guardian must provide a copy of the relevant order to the office; INCS will follow its terms. Absent a court order, both parents retain the right of access. Contact the office with custody-related questions.

A parent will be notified before a child leaves the premises in any non-emergency situation. An authorized investigator from DCS or local law enforcement may take a child from the premises if they have obtained lawful custody. Written permission from a parent or guardian is required in advance for each off-site activity; permission forms are sent home before every Community Expedition and field experience. Verbal permission is not sufficient except in emergencies.

Disenrollment

INCS is committed to serving every student and will make reasonable efforts to support students whose behavior, attendance, or circumstances create challenges. **Disenrollment is a last resort.** A student may be disenrolled in the following circumstances:

- Failure to maintain required immunization records or health documentation after written notice and a reasonable opportunity to comply
- Accumulation of unexcused absences resulting in a truancy determination under T.C.A. § 49-6-3001 where all progressive interventions have been exhausted
- Disciplinary action resulting in expulsion under the INCS student discipline policy (TPCSC LEA Policy 6317), following all required due-process protections
- A student's enrollment in another school

Before any disenrollment action, families receive written notice and an opportunity to be heard. Students with IEPs or 504 Plans are entitled to additional procedural protections under IDEA and Section 504 before any change in placement or disenrollment.

PreK Tuition & Fees

INCS is a public charter school and does **not charge tuition** for any student in Kindergarten through 8th grade. For PreK students, tuition is **\$8,500 per year**, charged in ten monthly installments of \$850. Families enroll in an automatic monthly payment plan; a member of the INCS team will contact families to establish this before the first payment is due.

If a family falls behind on payments, a school team member will reach out to discuss the situation and work toward a resolution. INCS will not remove a student from the program without first having that conversation with the family.

Smoke-Free Environment

INCS is a smoke-free and tobacco-free campus. Smoking, vaping, and the use of any tobacco or nicotine product are prohibited in all school buildings, on school grounds, and at all school-sponsored activities and events. This applies to students, staff, families, and visitors at all times.

Child Abuse Prevention

INCS is committed to the safety and protection of every child. Once each year, INCS offers families information and resources on the detection, reporting, and prevention of child abuse, consistent with a program approved by the Tennessee Department of Education. All INCS staff

are mandated reporters under Tennessee law. For immediate concerns, contact the Tennessee DCS Child Abuse Hotline at **1-877-237-0004**, available 24 hours a day.

Staff Credentials

Parents and guardians may request to view the professional credentials of any INCS program staff member at any time. Please contact the school office to make a request.

Toys & Lost and Found

Toys, games, music players, electronics, and similar items should not be brought to school unless requested by a teacher for special purposes. Exceptions include balls or other recreational items to be used only during recess. If an item is brought without permission, it will be held at school until picked up by a parent. At the end of the school year, all unclaimed items are discarded.

Misplaced toys or clothing are taken to the Lost and Found in the school office. If an item is lost, families should submit a Lost Item form and the school will return it if found. At the end of each trimester, remaining items are placed in the cafeteria for families to claim. Unclaimed items are donated or disposed of as appropriate.

Volunteers & Visitors

All faculty and staff wear an identification badge at all times while on campus. Volunteers and visitors for school activities are welcome and, for safety reasons, must sign in at the office before going to the classroom and must wear an identification badge while in the building. Visitors must also check out in the office when they leave for the day. All volunteers are subject to background check requirements in accordance with INCS policy.

ACKNOWLEDGMENT

ACKNOWLEDGMENT OF RECEIPT

By signing below, I confirm that I have received and read the Invictus Nashville Charter School Student & Family Handbook for the 2025–2026 school year and understand its contents. I understand that this handbook summarizes and references the authoritative INCS Policy Handbook, available at www.invictus-nash.org, and that I may contact the school office with any questions.

PARENT / GUARDIAN SIGNATURE

DATE

PARENT / GUARDIAN PRINTED NAME

STUDENT NAME & GRADE



Questions? Contact info@invictus-nash.org · 615-378-5490 · 2526 Lebanon Pike, Nashville, TN 37214